

123 John the Baptist

The voice in the wilderness who prepared the way for Jesus and pointed to him as the Lamb of God.

John was the son of the aged priest Zechariah and Elizabeth, born in answer to prayer. He appeared by the Jordan as a prophet in the style of Elijah, dressed in camel's hair. Crowds came to hear his blunt call to repent and be baptized. John baptized Jesus and then pointed his own followers to him. He never tried to keep the spotlight: "He must increase, but I must decrease." His courage cost him his life when he rebuked Herod Antipas for taking his brother's wife. Jesus said no one born of women was greater than John.

At a glance

Name	John, from Hebrew <i>Yochanan</i> , "the Lord is gracious"
Family	Son of Zechariah and Elizabeth; relative of Jesus (Luke 1:36)
When	Born c. 6–4 BC; ministry from c. AD 28–29 (Luke 3:1–3)
Key places	Wilderness of Judaea; the Jordan; Bethabara (John 1:28)
Key people	Jesus, Herod Antipas, Andrew, the Pharisees and Sadducees
Death	Beheaded by order of Herod Antipas (Matthew 14:10)
Role	Forerunner of the Christ (Isaiah 40:3; Malachi 3:1)
New Testament	All four Gospels and Acts

"Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world."

John 1:29, KJV

The life of John the Baptist

Dates are approximate (BC or AD). Luke dates the start of John's ministry to the fifteenth year of Tiberius, c. AD 28–29.

c. 7–5 BC <i>Before birth</i>	● Promised Gabriel tells Zechariah his son will go before the Lord in the spirit and power of Elijah. <i>Luke 1:13–17</i>
c. 6–4 BC <i>Eighth day</i>	● Named John His parents insist on the name John, and the hand of the Lord is with him. <i>Luke 1:57–66</i>
Youth	● In the deserts John grows strong in spirit and lives in the deserts until he appears to Israel. <i>Luke 1:80</i>
c. AD 28–29 <i>15th year of Tiberius</i>	● The word of God comes John preaches a baptism of repentance around the Jordan, and crowds come. <i>Luke 3:1–18; Matthew 3:1–12</i>
c. AD 28–29 <i>At the Jordan</i>	● Baptizes Jesus John protests but obeys. The Spirit descends like a dove, and a voice speaks from heaven. <i>Matthew 3:13–17</i>
Soon after	● Points to the Lamb He calls Jesus the Lamb of God, and two of his disciples, one of them Andrew, follow Jesus. <i>John 1:19–40</i>
Early in Jesus' ministry	● Imprisoned John rebukes Herod Antipas for taking Herodias, his brother's wife, and is imprisoned. <i>Luke 3:19–20; Matthew 11:2–6</i>
During Jesus' ministry	● Beheaded Prompted by Herodias, her daughter asks for John's head, and Herod grants it. <i>Matthew 14:3–12; Mark 6:17–29</i>

Key activities

Scholars debate whether John had links with the Essenes, a strict Jewish group in the Judean desert. Scripture does not say.

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- I Leapt for joy before birth.** When Mary greeted Elizabeth, the unborn John leapt in the womb. *Luke 1:41, 44*

 - 2 Lived simply.** He wore camel's hair and a leather belt and ate locusts and wild honey. *Matthew 3:4*

 - 3 Called for repentance.** "Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand." *Matthew 3:2*

 - 4 Baptized many.** People from Jerusalem, Judaea and the Jordan region were baptized by him, confessing their sins. *Matthew 3:5-6*

 - 5 Challenged the proud.** He called the Pharisees and Sadducees a "generation of vipers" and told them to bear fruit worthy of repentance. *Matthew 3:7-10*

 - 6 Gave practical advice.** Share coats and food; tax collectors, take no more than is due; soldiers, do no violence and be content with wages. *Luke 3:10-14*

 - 7 Refused the spotlight.** He said he was not the Christ and was unworthy to untie his shoes. *John 1:19-27*

 - 8 Baptized Jesus.** He said, "I have need to be baptized of thee," but did as Jesus asked. *Matthew 3:13-15*

 - 9 Pointed to the Lamb.** He twice called Jesus "the Lamb of God," and let his disciples leave to follow him. *John 1:29, 35-37*

 - 10 Rejoiced to decrease.** He called himself the friend of the bridegroom: "He must increase, but I must decrease." *John 3:26-30*

 - 11 Rebuked a king.** He told Herod, "It is not lawful for thee to have her." *Matthew 14:3-4*

 - 12 Brought his doubt to Jesus.** From prison he asked, "Art thou he that should come, or do we look for another?" *Matthew 11:2-6*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name John.

Old Testament

Isaiah 40:3	"The voice of him that crieth in the wilderness," applied to John
Malachi 3:1; 4:5–6	The messenger and Elijah; Jesus says John is "Elias" (Matt 11:14)
Echo: 2 Kings 1:8; Judges 13:4–5	Elijah's leather belt; Samson set apart from birth

New Testament

Matthew 11:7–19; Luke 7:24–35	Jesus praises John as more than a prophet
John 1:6–8	Sent "to bear witness of the Light"
John 1:21	Not Elijah in person, but in his "spirit and power" (Luke 1:17)
Acts 13:24–25; 19:1–7	Believers in Ephesus who knew only John's baptism
Josephus, Antiquities 18	Also records John's preaching and death

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did John tell the crowds, tax collectors and soldiers (Luke 3:10–14)?
2. *Understand:* Why might John later send to ask if Jesus was the one (Matthew 11:2–6)?
3. *Apply:* "He must increase, but I must decrease." What credit could you hand to Jesus this week?
4. *Apply:* What concrete change would repentance mean in your work, money or relationships?